

FLASH POINTS

BOMAI, FEBRUARY 21

Soldiers of 22 Rashtriya Rifles kill two devotees returning from a Sufi shrine for raising slogans against the army during routine frisking. Mobs shouting pro-freedom slogans clash with the army.

SHOPIAN, MAY 30

Bodies of Asiya and her pregnant sister-in-law Nilofer recovered after they went missing from an orchard. Omar says it was death by drowning. Protesters cry rape and murder by security forces. Post mortem confirms rape and Omar retracts his words. Six weeks later, Shopian is still uneasy.

BARAMULLA, JUNE 30

Riots break out after a woman alleges molestation by the police. CRPF firing kills a youth. Omar withdraws CRPF. When state police fail to control the rioters, CRPF is recalled.

savvy Omar told the press that he was "not going to respond to questions about Shopian and Baramulla". He did try to assert himself by ordering a massive overhaul of the police establishment. No less than 61 top officials were transferred.

As unrest broke out after the Baramulla firing and rioting spread to neighbouring towns, Omar's immediately withdrew the CRPF. But since his Plan B—the J&K Police—could not control the agitating mob, he soon had the CRPF back. His first reactions tend to be emotional rather than political, or even pragmatic. Moreover, he needs to be less sensitive to criticism. In a somewhat schoolboyish fashion he used to record his experiences with

statecraft on Facebook (a social networking site), including such posts as that he "has had it with security forces" after the Baramulla shooting. Earlier too as an MP he had begun to write a popular blog; he shut it down when critical posts began to appear.

Yet he is not insecure. He knows that there will be no challenge to his chief ministership, even though some of his partymen prefer the father. Neither will the Congress stage a coup against him. Unlike the PDP-Congress roulette rule where each party ruled for three years, there is no such arrangement in place with the National Conference (NC). Congress spokesmen refuse to criticise Omar. "I will not call it a frittering away of the mandate. There are forces in J&K that always try to polarise society," said Congress spokesman Manish Tiwari.

have earned him the sobriquet of a non-resident chief minister. His detractors claim he has spent 38 days in Delhi during the last six months. His children study at a school in the capital. More than that, what has worked against Omar is ironically all the hype that surrounded his ascension. It led to somewhat unrealistic expectations not just from a first timer but from any chief minister of the troubled state.

The Cub-e-Kashmir was heralded as a miracle worker who would usher in an era of new roads, schools and jobs. These do not happen overnight. "Kashmir is a special state so you cannot blame individuals," says Mehbooba, sounding surprisingly charitable. She is quick to add, "But Omar is the leader. He has to lead."

When he assumed office, Omar



THE RHETORIC OF RAPE AND RIOTS STILL RESOUNDS IN J&K

Omar's friendship with Rahul Gandhi—he was the young scion's choice for the top job—makes it difficult for the rest of the Congress to target him. Besides, the central Congress leadership sees him as its best bet. "The Muftis play the separatists' line; Ghulam Nabi Azad got embroiled in the Amarnath land row. Of the Abdullahs, the son is preferable over the father. All he lacks is experience. He will learn," says a Congress general secretary rather indulgently. The Sydenham College graduate is the right progressive face to woo investors. He seems to have the right ideas but is somehow unable to deliver on his blueprint for the state.

Omar's frequent trips to Delhi

wowed the Valley with his talk of zero tolerance for human right abuses and put the security forces on notice. Yet, at least 15 civilians have been killed within the first six months of his rule. While basking in the afterglow of his oath taking, he set up impossible goal posts like promising the withdrawal of the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act). "He has since realised that Kashmir is a many layered onion. The moment you start peeling a layer, your eyes water so much that you cannot see clearly," says an NC colleague. Omar needs to get a vision in place fast. When he took office, hardcore admirers called him Kashmir's Barack Obama. Six months later, he still has to prove that yes, he can. ■